

Cleveland Heights, St. Ed seek to finish business



St. Edward coach Eric Flannery directs a practice session.

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

After leading Cleveland Heights to a 91-66 victory over Euclid in a Division I district basketball final at Cleveland South two weeks ago, Tigers All-Ohio senior forward Theo Dixon was not in the mood to boast or celebrate.

BOYS BASKETBALL

"Our job is not done yet," Dixon said as his teammates cut the nets.

Dixon, who has experienced the joy and the heartbreak of postseason play, will be satisfied only if the scoreboard in St. John Arena in Columbus late Saturday afternoon flashes: "Cleveland Heights, Division I state champion!"

Cleveland Heights (22-3), ranked 10th in the final Associated Press big-school state poll, faces unranked Springfield North (19-6) tomorrow night at 9 p.m. in a state semifinal in St. John Arena. If successful, the Tigers will return to St. John Arena on Saturday at 2 p.m. for the state championship game.

Coached by 27-year veteran Jim Cappelletti, Cleveland Heights is making its fifth final-four appearance and its fourth in

five seasons. The Tigers were big-school state runners-up in 1975 and 1995.

Like Dixon, St. Edward junior point guard Steve Logan was reserved after keying the Eagles' 63-38 victory over Valley Forge in Saturday night's regional final at the University of Toledo.

Although pleased that he and his teammates clinched a second straight state final-four appearance, Logan was "all business" during a post-game interview.

"Right now, this is a great feeling," Logan said after he scored a game-high 25 points. "But you better believe that we have a lot of unfinished business to take care of."

After being eliminated by Cincinnati La Salle in last season's state semifinals, Logan and his teammates have been on a mission.

The Eagles, under the direction of first-year head coach and St. Edward graduate Eric Flannery, will take a 24-1 record and a 19-game winning streak into tomorrow's 6 p.m. Division I semifinal against Zanesville (24-1). Zanesville and St. Edward were ranked 1-2, respectively, in the final AP state poll.

"Wouldn't that be tremendous?" said Cappelletti, referring to the possibility of a Cleveland

area state final in Division I.

Cappelletti and his staff are familiar not only with St. Edward, but Springfield North and Zanesville.

In 1995, Cleveland Heights rallied from a 17-point deficit with 2:38 remaining in the third quarter and defeated Springfield North, 69-61, in the state semifinals. Dixon, then a sophomore, scored 21 points, grabbed eight rebounds and made six steals.

The next night, the Tigers faced Zanesville in the state championship game, losing to the Blue Devils, 69-68, in overtime. Zanesville All-Ohio center Seth Martin, who also started as a sophomore, gave the Blue Devils a 69-68 lead by hitting one of two free throws with 57.6 seconds left. Zanesville held on as Cleveland Heights missed four shots in the final 50 seconds.

Last season, Cleveland Heights' bid for a fourth consecutive final-four appearance was halted by St. Edward, 65-61, in the regional semifinals at Cleveland State.

This season, Cleveland Heights handed Zanesville its only setback as the Tigers, behind 26 points by All-Ohio senior guard Jamaal Harris, defeated the Blue Devils, 56-54, in the semifinals of the Gahanna Lincoln Holiday Tournament.



Cleveland Heights coach Jim Cappelletti instructs his Tigers.

Although a Cleveland area big-school state final would be a first, Cleveland Heights is focusing on the job at hand — Springfield North.

"They are a lot bigger than the team we played in '95," Cappelletti said of North, which advanced to the state semifinals by defeating Cincinnati Aiken, 55-52. "They have a couple of 6-7 and 6-8 kids, play mostly a 2-3 zone defense and are very patient

on offense.

"It seems like they prefer to give you the outside shot. We're going to have to protect the ball and hopefully do some things with our pressure."

"I just hope we don't get off to one of our slow starts, like we have done in the past in Columbus."

St. Edward, which made its final-four debut last season, also is familiar with its semifinal opponent.

Zanesville, behind 17 points by Martin, defeated the Eagles, 53-51, in double overtime in last season's McDonald & Co. High School Classic in Gund Arena.

Tomorrow night's matchup has all the makings of another nail-biter as St. Edward and Zanesville play tenacious defense and are adept at the half-court game on offense.

"Defense has been our No. 1 priority all season," said Flannery, who was a member of St. Edward's regional semifinalist team in 1989. "We've been able to hold teams to an average of about 44 or 45 points. Our offense is definitely fueled by our defense."

The Eagles, who returned all five starters from last season, have limited 19 of their 25 opponents to fewer than 50 points and five of them to fewer than 40.

A battle of his own

Buchtel standout Doyle Robinson helps deal with mom's death by honing basketball skills, leading Griffins to state semifinals

By E.L. ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Doyle Robinson is at war with his emotions.

He didn't realize it would be such a tough battle.

"My mom died [of an aneurysm] when I was 12 years old, and I've had a hard time dealing with that," the Buchtel boys basketball player said. "My mom was my best friend. After she died, I was mad with the world for a long time. I didn't want to hear anybody else's situation. It was my way or nobody's way."

He's still scraping the emotional scars. Only, most of the world doesn't see it.

Just what do folks see when they look at Robinson?

Here's what Buchtel fans see: an important link in their boys basketball team. An engineer who has led the team to a 20-5 record, sectional, district and regional championships and a trip to this week's Division II state semifinals in Columbus.

Here's what Robinson himself sees: a whirlpool of feelings. Anger. Rage. Confusion. Sadness. Happiness. Joy. He's the youngest of five children, having three brothers and one sister.

Here's what bird's-eye view sees: a tattoo on Robinson's right arm. It is a picture of a basketball hoop attached to a headstone. The headstone is symbolic. It represents a backboard and his mother's strength. His mother's name, Eva, is attached to the headstone.

Here's what the girls see: a dreamboat.

Here's what Robinson's 2-year-old son sees: a proud papa.

Here's what the average spectator sees: talent, talent and more talent. A slasher with a wicked cross-over dribble and a soft jumper. A flashy 6-4 junior point guard who is strong enough to score a myriad of points, yet unselfish enough to work his teammates into the plan with passes.

Here's what many defenders have gotten to see: Robinson's favorite move. A cross-over dribble to the foul line, where he pulls up for a jump shot.

Here's what parts of Europe saw: Robinson during the summer. He was part of a Columbus basketball club that spent a week in places such as Switzerland and Italy. The basketball was good, the food wasn't. Robinson said that "they served stuff like lamb over there," and "in Switzerland, it cost \$11 for a Burger King value meal."

Here's what Buchtel's coaching staff has seen: a jersey with number 00 worn by Robinson's freshman season. That number stood for his mother, for the fact that she had passed away. Robinson switched to number 10 his sophomore season. That number represents his mother's birthday, June 10. As Robinson put it: "I figured I could get something better than 00."

Here's what the stat person sees: averages of 19 points, 14 rebounds, seven assists, five steals and two blocks.

Here's what opposing players see: trouble.

Here's what opposing coaches see: in most cases, a loss.

Here's what college scouts see: conference championships down the road. So many schools are drooling. Wake Forest.



Doyle Robinson: "It still hurts at times, I loved my mother."



Buchtel's Doyle Robinson drives against Firestone's Justin Levy during a regular-season game.

Clemson, Syracuse.

Here's what NBA scouts might see: a possible future, depending on how well Robinson fares in college and how hard he works.

Finally, here's what Robinson's godmother, Cassandra Knight, sees: hope.

"The child has so much love and compassion in his heart," Knight said.

Knight and her husband are two of the biggest reasons Robinson has been able to cope. After his mother's death, Robinson stayed with an aunt for a few years before moving in with the Knights. The move has paid big dividends.

"Doyle is still trying to deal with what happened to his mother," Knight said. "At certain times, I can look at him and tell something is bothering him. He talks about how his friends can lie on the bed and talk with their parents. I told him to understand I could never replace his mother, but that I'm there for him."

Advice, guidance and love. Knight provides all these things for Robinson.

Knight and her husband try to attend every game. They know support is important.

"I sit behind the team," Knight said. "I don't get nervous, but I can get a feel for when Doyle is angry. If he's getting fouled and the ref doesn't call it, then Doyle will just start shooting 3-pointers. He figures he's going to do what he has to."

"I can also tell if Doyle is not feeling well, if for some reason he's not putting everything into the game. For example, at Thursday's [regional semifinal against Canton South] game, I told my husband during the first half that Doyle didn't look good. And sure enough, after the game, Doyle told me that he had thrown up at halftime."

One other pointer from Knight: Robinson

will make his free throw if he comes up on his toes and flicks his wrist.

"If he does those two things, it's going in," Knight said. "It's phenomenal to watch him play."

Just ask opposing coaches.

"Doyle is the best all-around player in our area," said St. Vincent-St. Mary coach Mitch Gerycz, whose team beat Buchtel during the regular season but lost to the Griffins in the playoffs. "Doyle can do so many things. He can go out on the perimeter and handle the jump shot. He can post. He can rebound. And perhaps the most important thing is he can keep his teammates under control."

"He plays both ends of the court. On defense, he's the type of player that can do things with such ease, people might mistake that for a lackadaisical attitude. But I didn't think that at all."

Copley coach Duane Daily said Robinson has unlimited potential.

"I think the sky is the limit for him," Daily said. "He definitely has the potential to be a Division I player in college. He's the total package, and he can go big time. How big? That's up to him. I didn't have to play him this year, and I'm thankful for that."

Robinson will not allow this shower of praise to drown him. He realizes there are more important things in life than getting a big ego. Besides, his mother would want her son to be humble.

"It still hurts at times; I loved my mother," Robinson said. "For a while, it was rough. But I've had a lot of people talking to me. This year, I really started getting my confidence back."

His mother wouldn't have it any other way.

Seven area players gain All-Ohio honors

Steve Logan of St. Edward; Theo Dixon and Jamaal Harris of Cleveland Heights; Tim Schaefer of Olmsted Falls; Rashon Brown of Benedictine; and Doylan Robinson of Buchtel head the area representation on the 1996-97 Associated Press Divisions I and II boys All-Ohio basketball teams.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Logan, a 5-10 junior point guard who will lead the Eagles against top-ranked Zanesville in a Division I state semifinal game tomorrow night at 6 p.m. in St. John Arena in Columbus, was selected to the first team on the recommendations of a statewide media panel. Logan keyed a 19-1 regular season and helped St. Edward to its highest state ranking (second) in school history.

Dixon, a 6-6 senior forward who averaged more than 21 points during the regular season, and Harris, a 6-1 senior guard who averaged more than 22 points, were chosen for the second team in Division I. Dixon and Harris will lead the Tigers against Springfield North in the other big-school state semifinal, tomorrow night at 9 p.m. in St. John Arena.

Schaefer, a 6-8 senior center,

was selected for the first team in Division II, and Brown, a 6-0 senior guard, and Robinson, a 6-4 junior forward, were second-team selections. Brown and Robinson have led their teams to the state semifinals by averaging 20.5 and 19.9 points, respectively.

Schaefer, a two-time player of the year in the Southwestern Conference and the Division II co-player of the year in the Northeast Lakes District, keyed the Bulldogs' drive to a 23-2 record, a third consecutive regional appearance and a second straight undefeated mark in the SWC. He shot 73.5 percent from the field and 84 percent from the free-throw line.

Third-team honors in Division I went to Garfield Heights junior forward William "Sonny" Johnson. Johnson led The Plain Dealer's seven-county coverage area with an average of 26.3 points.

James O'Neal Johnson, who guided Glenville to a 20-0 regular season, and Bob Wosnon, who led a Shaker Heights team laden with underclassmen to an 18-2 record, shared Division I coach-of-the-year honors with Dave Hoover of Canton McKinley and Gil Guerrero of Toledo Start.

STAFF, WIRE REPORTS

BOYS DIVISION I ALL-OHIO BASKETBALL TEAM

COLUMBUS (AP) — The 1996-97 Associated Press Division I Boys All-Ohio basketball team, based on the recommendations of a state media panel (with school, height, grade and scoring average).

DIVISION I

FIRST TEAM: Kenny Gregory, Columbus Independence 6-foot-4, senior, 25.1 points per game; Seth Martin, Zanesville 6-7, Sr., 19.5; Andre Hutson, Trotwood-Madison 6-8, Sr., 21.0; Roben Cullum, Toledo St. Francis 6-5, Sr., 23.0; Steve Logan, St. Edward 5-10, Jr., 13.8.

SECOND TEAM: Doug Davis, Columbus Westland 6-3, Sr., 22.2; Reed Sims, GlenOak 6-6, Sr., 21.0; Steve Flores, East Liverpool 6-8, Sr., 21.6; Jamaal Harris, Cleveland Heights 6-1, Sr., 22.8; Theo Dixon, Cleveland Heights 6-6, Sr., 21.1; Mike Ensminger, Cincinnati Oak Hills 6-7, Sr., 22.7; Mike Redd, Columbus West 6-5, Sr., 25.7; Eric Thomas, Springfield North 6-5, Sr., 18.0.

THIRD TEAM: Kalan Smith, Trotwood-Madison 6-2, Sr., 21.8; Brooks Hall, Troy 6-5, Soph., 22.7; William "Sonny" Johnson, Garfield

Heights 6-4, Jr., 26.3; Kevin King, Columbus West 6-2, Sr., 23.9; Travis Young, Zanesville 6-1, Sr., 10.3; Floyd Campbell, Toledo Whitmer 6-4, Jr., 22.0; Marco Morgan, Massillon 6-9, Sr., 20.4; Arko Jackson, Canton McKinley 6-4, Sr., 11.0.

Player of the year: Kenny Gregory, Columbus Independence.

Coaches of the year: James O'Neal Johnson, Glenville; Bob Wosnon, Shaker Heights; Dave Hoover, Canton McKinley; Gil Guerrero, Toledo Start.

AREA SPECIAL MENTION

Mike Perry, Barberton; Joe Ashburn, Akron Garfield; Jason Wolsten, Mentor; Ryan Patton, Valley Forge; Chris Chambers, Bedford; Doug Taylor, Admiral King.

AREA HONORABLE MENTION

Anthony Jackson, Akron East; Jammond Hogg, Akron Garfield; Nick Lapschew, Brunswick; Chris Pap, Medina; Dwight Cash, Glenville; Lee Nossie, Euclid; Jason Schaff, Mentor; Jon Higgins, Shaker Heights; Sam Clancy, St. Edward; Wesley Fullen, Collingwood; Andre Anderson, Shaw

BOYS DIVISION II ALL-OHIO BASKETBALL TEAM

COLUMBUS (AP) — The 1996-97 Associated Press Division II Boys All-Ohio basketball team, based on the recommendations of a state media panel (with school, height, grade and scoring average).

DIVISION II

FIRST TEAM: Ryan Lenti, Troy 6-foot-4, senior, 24.9 points per game; Aaron Turner, Columbus Olentangy 6-7, Sr., 17.2; Jon Sanderson, Lexington 6-7, Sr., 17.2; T.J. Turner, Hillsboro 6-3, Sr., 18.7; Craig Sanders, Cincinnati McNichols 6-2, Sr., 24.4; Shaughn McKelvey, New Concord John Glenn 6-4, Sr., 19.8; Jason Thomas, Edison Local 6-7, Sr., 18.5; Steve Kray, Ashland Edgewood 6-1, Sr., 18.3.

SECOND TEAM: Eugene Land, Cincinnati Roger Bacon 6-7, Jr., 20.2; Mark Prater, Hamilton Badin 6-4, Sr., 15.7; Doylan Robinson, Buchtel 6-4, Jr., 19.9; Rashon Brown, Benedictine 6-0, Sr., 20.5; Michael Boyd, Beavely 6-7, Sr., 18.8; Jason Hamilton, Colchester 5-10, Jr., 23.0; Louis Green, Napoleon 6-5, Sr., 22.5; Aaron Kamitz, Cincinnati 6-7, Sr., 19.3.

THIRD TEAM: Danny McGeedy, Kettering Avon 6-3, Sr., 16.6; Cain Dolbos, Springboro 6-6, Sr., 24.0; Jason Hartman, Fairfield Union 6-5, Sr., 20.2; Derek Dunn, Bressville Mesdowbrook 6-2, Sr., 21.3; Brad Schumaker, Ottawa-Glandorf 6-2, Sr., 12.1; Brian Ziegler, Canal Fulton Northwest 6-0, Sr., 24.4.

Players of the year: Ryan Lenti, Troyway; Aaron Turner, Columbus Milfin.

Coaches of the year: Gale Barnes, Columbus Milfin; Bob Von Kaenel, Dover; Jim Lower, Canal Fulton Northwest; Al Runyan, Ashland Edgewood.

AREA SPECIAL MENTION

John Storey, Olmsted Falls; Chris Stakich, University School; Bob Rosol, Fairview; Brad Reusch, Highland; Tim Chestwood, Benedictine.

AREA HONORABLE MENTION

Victor Cox, Akron North; Dustin Scott, Buchtel; Scott Sney, Keystone; Jeff Flaite, Rocky River; Keith Lillash, Lake Catholic.

AT A GLANCE

75th Boys State Basketball Tournament

Where: St. John Arena, Ohio State University, on Lane Ave., between Olentangy River Rd. and High St.

When: Tomorrow, with semifinal games in Division II at noon and 3 p.m. and in Division I at 6 p.m. and 9 p.m. Friday's semifinals are at 1:15 p.m. and 4 p.m. in Division IV and 6:45 p.m. and 9:30 p.m. in Division III. Championship games will be Saturday at 11 a.m. for Division II, 2 p.m. for Division I, 3 p.m. for Division IV and 9 p.m. for Division III.

Tickets: Most games are sellouts. Tickets not sold at competing schools are returned for sale at St. John Arena box office.

DICK ZUNT

BOYS STATE TOURNAMENT PAIRINGS

The pairings for the 75th Boys Basketball State Tournament in St. John Arena in Columbus.

Tomorrow: Semifinals — St. Edward (24-1) vs. Zanesville (24-1), 6 p.m.; Springfield North (20-6) vs. Cleveland Heights (20-3), 9 p.m.

Saturday: Championship — 2 p.m.

Tomorrow: Semifinals — Buchtel (20-6) vs. Hamilton Badin (20-2), noon; Columbus Milfin (21-3) vs. Benedictine (21-3), 3 p.m.

Saturday: Championship — 11 a.m.

Division III

Friday: Semifinals — Villa Angela-St. Joseph (16-6) vs. Bolton (14-12), 6:45 p.m.; Patrick Henry (21-4) vs. Dayton Christian (23-3), 9:30 p.m.

Saturday: Championship — 8 p.m.

Division IV

Friday: Semifinals — Springfield Catholic Central (11-13) vs. Zanesville Rosencrans (25-1), 1:15 p.m.; Nookwich St. Paul (24-2) vs. Lincolnview (25-0), 4 p.m.

Saturday: Championship — 5 p.m.